

"The Ice Cave"

Lupin Creative Writing — Survival/Danger Story 13 August 2026

13 / 25

A genuinely tense idea, told too fast — and with more slips than a first read shows.

You've got a real hook here — a friend dangling over an ice hole, a countdown rescue, a wall of ice sealing the exit. But the piece rushes through the middle in a handful of lines, and it carries 7 genuine errors in under 200 words: two misspellings of words you'd already spelled correctly elsewhere on the page, the same "off" instead of "of/on" mistake twice, and a missing word.

Continuity from your last report: your last piece was flagged for trailing off on "..." instead of a real ending — this is now **three pieces in a row** that stop this way. It's clearly become a habit under time pressure, not a one-off. This time, make finishing the story the very last thing you do before you put your pen down, even if it's just one sentence.

MARK BREAKDOWN

Content & Ideas

4/7

A strong, genuinely dangerous scenario (an ice-hole rescue against a collapsing cave), but it's compressed into a handful of lines — the actual rescue happens in one sentence with no sense of how close, cold or frightening it really was.

Structure & Organisation

4/6

Good instinct for pacing — two separate one-line paragraphs (the opening, and "He was hanging on by a strand of hair") used deliberately for dramatic pause. Let down by the unfinished ending.

Style: Vocabulary & Variety

3/6

Some precise words ("musty", "mysterious", "tiresome") and a reach for a simile/pun ("like a chicken with its head off"), but a missing word blunts the joke and "hole" and "path" both repeat.

Technical Accuracy

2/6

7 genuine errors in under 200 words — two misspellings of words spelled correctly elsewhere on the same page, the "off" for "of/on" mistake made twice, and a missing word. Visible self-editing is a real strength (see Strengths), but this still needs a proper reread before you call a piece finished.

THE ICE CAVE

It was a choice between life and death.

Nobody had ever thought that this would ever happen. Earlier, my friends and I were planning to explore this dark, musty cave, which was in an icy mountain. We checked that we had everything: ice picks, helnets¹, flashlights and food.

We started off by climbing using the metal ice piks² until we reached the mouth off³ the mysterious cave. Inside⁴, there were two paths, so we split into two groups of two.

Moments later, one of our friends, Bob, was suddenly yelling his⁵ like a chicken with its head off. "Help!" he screamed while we came darting from the other path.

He was hanging on by a strand of hair.

In front of us there was a large, deep hole, where he was gripping an ice pick. Based off⁶ the ice, we could tell it was going to break in any minute⁷. Fortunately we could reach his hips, where we strapped a rope.

"3... 2... 1... Pull!" I chanted, and after thirty tiresome minutes which felt like a day, we managed to pull him out. Suddenly a wall of ice covered the exit just as we were leaving. We were trapped...

CORRECTIONS

- 1 Spelling.
"helmets"
- 2 Spelling — same word as above ("picks"), correct earlier in the piece, misspelled here.
"picks"
- 3 Wrong preposition — "the mouth off the cave" should be "of."
"...the mouth of the mysterious cave."
- 4 Missing full stop — "cave inside" runs two ideas together as one sentence.
"...mysterious cave. Inside, there were two paths..."
- 5 Missing word — the joke needs "head off" before "like a chicken", or it just reads as "yelling his... like a chicken."
"...was suddenly yelling his head off, like a chicken with its head off."
- 6 Wrong preposition again — "based on," not "based off." This is the same mistake as Correction 3, worth remembering as one rule, not two separate slips.
"Based on the ice, we could tell..."

7 Wrong preposition — "in any minute" isn't standard English.

"...it was going to break at any moment."

STRENGTHS

STRUCTURE & CRAFT

- Opening straight into danger with *"It was a choice between life and death"* as its own line — a real hook, no slow build-up needed.
- *"He was hanging on by a strand of hair"* isolated as its own one-line paragraph — you're using this device on purpose now, not by accident.
- The *"3... 2... 1... Pull!"* countdown is a good instinct for building tension through dialogue rather than description.

EDITING & LANGUAGE

- Real evidence of redrafting as you write — you crossed out and rebuilt the "large deep hole" sentence, the group-splitting sentence, and correctly cut "started to pull" before "we strapped a rope" so the final sentence reads cleanly, rather than leaving your first attempt.
- Reaching for imagery under pressure with the *"chicken with its head off"* simile, even though the wording needs tightening.
- Good precise word choices: *"musty"*, *"mysterious"*, *"tiresome"*.

MODEL VERSION — SAME STORY, FULL MARKS

SAME PLOT, SAME CHARACTERS — WRITTEN TO A 25/25 STANDARD

It was a choice between life and death.

Nobody had ever imagined that today would be the day everything went wrong. Earlier, my friends and I had planned to explore a dark, musty cave hidden deep in an icy mountain range. We checked our kit twice: ice picks, helmets, flashlights, and enough food to last the day.

We began the climb, driving our picks into the frozen rock until we finally reached the cave's mouth. Inside, the tunnel split into two paths, so we split into two groups of two, agreeing to meet back at the entrance within the hour.

Barely five minutes in, a scream tore through the tunnel. "Help!" Bob's voice echoed off the ice walls, high and frantic, like a chicken with its head cut off. We sprinted back down our own path, boots skidding on the frozen ground, hearts hammering.

He was hanging on by a strand of hair.

In front of us gaped a wide, bottomless-looking hole, and Bob dangled over it, his knuckles white around an ice pick wedged into the wall. Thin cracks were already spidering out from where the pick met the ice — it would not hold much longer. Without a word, one of us unclipped the rope and looped it under his arms while the rest of us gripped his wrists.

"Three! Two! One! Pull!" I roared, and we heaved together, boots braced against the rock. Thirty exhausting minutes later — minutes that felt like hours — we finally dragged him onto solid ground, shaking and gasping, but alive.

We did not have time to celebrate. A deafening crack echoed through the cave, and a wall of ice sealed the exit shut behind us. We looked at each other in silence, torches trembling in our hands. We were trapped — but we were alive, and as long as we were alive, we still had a way out to find.

What makes this version full marks: **every sentence is technically clean** (no missing words, no wrong prepositions), **it actually finishes** (the last line resolves the danger into a new, forward-looking problem instead of trailing off), and it **slows down at the one moment that matters** — the rescue — with real sensory detail (cracking ice, white knuckles, boots braced) instead of rushing past it in one sentence.

NEXT STEPS

Focus for next time — 1) Finish the story properly — three pieces in a row have stopped on "...", so plan your last line before you start writing, not after. 2) Slow the rescue down: add a sentence or two of what it looked, sounded or felt like as the ice cracked, instead of jumping straight to "we managed to pull him out."

3) Read your last sentence back before moving on — that's how you'll catch missing words like in

Correction 2.

